

New Zealand



NEW ZEALAND CONSISTS mainly of two large islands—North and South Island. North Island has a warm, temperate climate with active volcanoes. South Island is colder, with glaciers, mountains, and beech forests.

New Zealand does not have a great variety of bird species. This is mainly due to its isolated position. It drifted away from the other landmasses millions of years ago as a result of continental drift. However, the few species it has are very unusual. This is because New Zealand had very few mammals when it drifted off on its own, so the birds there began to live like mammals, running about and nesting on the ground. Many birds, such as the kiwi and the takahe, stopped flying altogether because there were no mammal predators to escape from. Unfortunately, these flightless birds later became easy prey for stoats and other mammals that people introduced to the islands.

Little penguin

The smallest penguin in the world lives around the coasts and islands of New Zealand. The little penguin, also known as the blue or fairy penguin, spends the day fishing at sea, but comes ashore at night. In the breeding season, little penguins pair up with the same mates at the same nest site year after year. They nest in a cave, among rocks or grass, or in a burrow.



Strong flippers and webbed feet for swimming fast underwater

Little penguin
(*Eudyptula minor*)
Length: 1 ft 6 in (45 cm)

Kea

This unusual parrot lives in much colder habitats than most others, sometimes even in snow. In summer, it lives in the mountains but it moves down to the forests on the coast in winter. The kea is named after the sound of its call, which echoes around the steep mountainsides. Both parents take care of the young until they are ready to leave the nest after about 13 weeks.



Kea
(*Nestor notabilis*)
Length: 1 ft 7 in (48 cm)

Long top bill for tearing into fruit, leaves, insects, and dead animals. The male's top bill is longer than the female's.



The bird's bill curves to the right, yet it holds its head to the left as it feeds.

Wrybill
(*Anarhynchus frontalis*)
Length: 8 in (21 cm)

Wrybill

The wrybill is named after its crooked, or wry, bill which bends to the right at the tip, although no one is quite sure why. It is a type of wading bird related to the plover. The wrybill breeds on the stones and shingle of large riverbeds on South Island from August to December. The bird and its eggs are well camouflaged among the stones. In January it migrates to North Island.

